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Beyond Predictions: How Publishers Should Actually Focus Heading into 2026

Priti Powell, the Chief Revenue Officer at Assertive Yield, provided a detailed analysis below on how publishers can refocus their efforts as the industry transitions from prediction to execution in the coming year.



The [ExchangeWire piece](#) gets one thing absolutely right: 2026 won't reward buzzwords; it will reward clarity. For publishers, the challenge isn't understanding what is coming. It's deciding where to place attention, investment, and energy when everything claims to be "strategic."

[Priti Powell](#), the Chief Revenue Officer at [Assertive Yield](#), provided a detailed analysis below on how publishers can refocus their efforts as the industry transitions from prediction to execution in the coming year.

Stop Chasing "New" & Start Stress-Testing What You Already Run

The industry loves forecasting revolutions, but most revenue leakage still comes from:

- [bloated bidstreams](#)
- redundant demand paths
- tools that overlap but don't compound value

Before adding another AI layer or marketplace abstraction, publishers should ask: Does this meaningfully improve decision-making at the impression level, or just add reporting after the fact?

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Treat Supply Quality as a Business Lever, Not a Talking Point

“Supply quality” has become a safe phrase; everyone agrees with it, but few operationalize it. Real supply quality means:

- fewer, more [intentional demand paths](#)
- smarter traffic routing based on performance, not assumptions
- understanding which impressions deserve competition, and which don't

This shift isn't philosophical. It's economic. Publishers who actively shape their supply will outperform those who simply expose it.

AI Should Reduce Cognitive Load, Not Increase It

AI will absolutely play a role in 2026. But publishers should be skeptical of anything that:

- requires constant manual interpretation
- produces insights without clear actions
- optimizes around revenue instead of for it

The most valuable automation won't be flashy. It will quietly eliminate inefficiencies, surface fewer, better decisions, and give teams time back. If Artificial Intelligence creates more dashboards than outcomes, it's not helping.

Transparency Is No Longer a “Nice to Have”, It's a Defensive Strategy

As regulation, brand scrutiny, and buyer consolidation increase, publishers must be able to:

- explain how inventory flows
- justify pricing and demand choices
- defend supply decisions with data

Transparency isn't about appeasing buyers, it's about protecting long-term leverage in the ecosystem. Publishers who can clearly articulate how their supply is managed will be in a stronger position as programmatic economics tighten.

Sustainability Will Become Operational, Not Symbolic

In 2026, sustainability won't be a separate initiative. It will be a byproduct of well-run systems. As environmental impact is moving out of PR decks and into procurement conversations. Reducing waste in the bidstream isn't just "green", it's efficient. Lower duplication, smarter routing, and cleaner paths benefit:

- revenue
- infrastructure costs
- brand trust

The Bigger Shift Publishers Should Prepare For

The underlying theme isn't AI, identity, or automation. It's this: Publishers are moving from passive participants to active operators. The winners won't be those who adopt every new framework. They'll be the ones who decide deliberately what not to do. Focus beats novelty. Control beats complexity. And execution beats prediction, every time.

Where the Right Partners Matter

As publishers move from passive participation to active operation, the role of partners must change as well. The most valuable partners in 2026 won't be those tied to specific demand sources or short-term incentives. They will be demand-agnostic by design, built to help publishers take back control, not just observe performance after the fact. That means providing:

- reporting and analytics that explain what's happening and why
- decision layers that support revenue management across an increasingly complex stack
- AI-backed tools that help publishers shape supply, reduce waste, and optimize yield in real time

Complexity isn't going away. The opportunity is owning it, with systems that connect data, decisions, and execution in one place.

This is where [Assertive Yield](#) operates: as a comprehensive, demand-agnostic platform that gives publishers the tools to manage today's realities while building the infrastructure needed to adapt tomorrow.

Conclusion

There is new tech emerging, but do those business strategies solve yours? More importantly, how is their AI offering helping you to drive quality content to consumers?

In a market full of platforms, wrappers, and AI-driven promises, publishers should ask a harder

question: are these solutions truly serving the business we intend to build, or are we quietly adapting our product, editorial, and monetization strategy to fit the technology?

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Written by



Priti Powell

Chief Revenue Officer

As a senior executive, Ms. Powell has deep experience in the areas of go-to-market strategy, publisher development, client success, marketing, and communications, primarily in the ad tech and consulting industries. Priti's career is distinguished by her leadership roles at organizations including The Trade Desk, OpenWeb, PubMatic, and PwC. With versatile experience within the Ad Tech ecosystem, particularly as the former Global Head of OpenWrap at PubMatic, leading Customer Success at OpenWeb and driving growth for TTD's OpenPath and UID2 solutions, she brings a wealth of knowledge in assisting Assertive Yield's publisher community in navigating today's evolving market.





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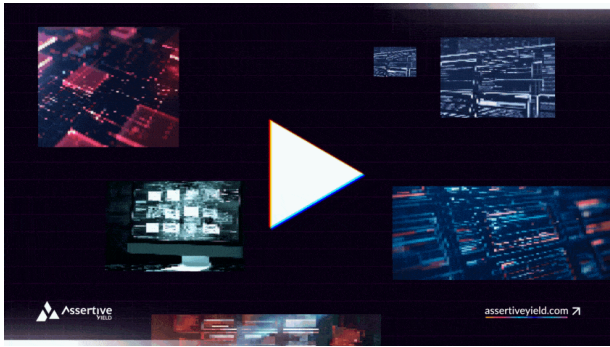


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